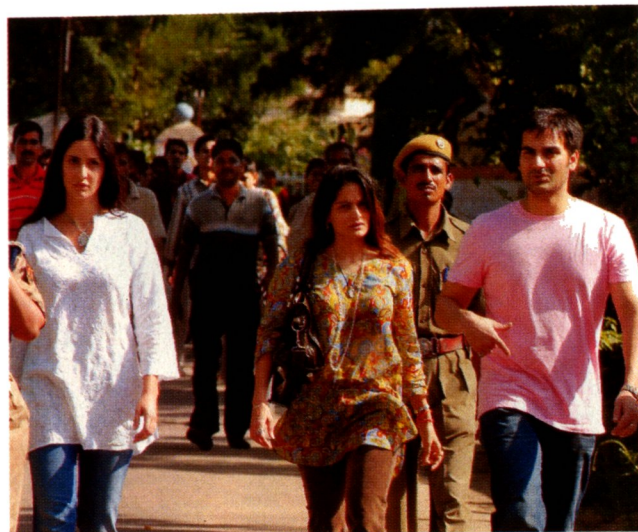




hop across to Natraj Hotel and try to convince Raj Kapoor's wife, distraught by her errant husband's affair with Vyjanthimala, to return home, or when Dharmendra would accept *Sholay* only because he wanted to prevent Sanjeev Kumar from romancing Hema Malini. The Khan household in Bandra is one of the last of Classic Bollywood. As Salman buddy and sometime producer Sunil Manchanda says: "In all the 15 years I have known Salim Khan, his door has never been shut. You push it and you're in, with a plate of food in your hand and a drink if you need one." Special friends know a spot outside his son's door where the keys to his flat are kept. If the master of the home is not in, they can let themselves in, use the bar, the gym, even the kitchen.

But even if the nights go on till 3 a.m., with friends of friends pouring in, Salman's producers have rarely suffered, unless he loses his hair in some delicate weaving operation as he did during *Jaan-e-Mann* or simply doesn't like the co-star, as in *London Dreams*, which he shot for all of two days. His native intelligence, well camouflaged by his intermittent American accent, is on display in his career choices. He knows his limitations and will never do anything that challenges it—which would explain his refusing to do *Chak De! India* and *Jodha Akbar* (much before Rai entered the project). He likes to work with friends, and will even give in to silly things like wearing a necklace in Nadiadwala's *Har Dil Jo Pyaar Karega*, and his helping hand to youngsters has now acquired leg-

FAMILY TO THE RESCUE: Salman's parents and girlfriend visit him in jail endary proportions—winging its way from body building tips to Hrithik Roshan to recommendations to producers for Himesh Reshammiya. His movies, from *Maine Pyar Kiya* in 1989, have invariably been successful, yet as Salim Khan says, "he has never been considered an actor. But why have so many filmmakers, from Barjatya to Sanjay Leela Bhansali made multiple films with him?" Or why does a complex constituency—from those who offer Friday prayers in Jama Masjid to young body builders in Jatland—forgive his incessant hamming?

The opinion on Salman's punishment varies from the orchestrated emotionalism of his friends to the anger of environmentalists. Kuldeep

Vishnoi, a lawyer who represents the Vishnoi community says Salman got permission to travel abroad, to countries that do not have an extradition treaty with India. "So where is the question of victimisation?" he asks. Debi Goenka, executive trustee, Conservation Action Trust, also believes the punishment is justified. "A person like him, who should have been setting an example for others has been doing just the opposite. Hunting animals cannot be considered a sport," says Goenka. Nor is he the only celebrity so charged. Mansoor Ali Khan Pataudi also faces a similar case for hunting around his village in Haryana in 2005. Salman is also accused in a hit and run 2002 case in Mumbai where one person was killed and four others injured. The case is still on the trial stage. In 2002, he was also accused of being close to the underworld, when Chhota Shakeel aide Anjum Phajlani claimed that Salman had agreed to work in *Chori Chori Chupke Chupke* after receiving threats from Shakeel who had allegedly financed the film through Bharat Shah. Salman, however, denied the charges in the court.

In the shadow world between celebrity spotlight and the media glare, Salman's role has already been cast in stone. It's not the little emperor of Salmanland, shocked at the hostility he faces. It's of one who hunts for danger and who's always on the wrong side of law. It's an image the lynch mob, with its hunger for news that mines glamour for disaster, knows well and is waiting for. **with Prerana Thakurdesai**

FLIP FLOP

YEAR SO FAR

Partner: Year's biggest hit at Rs 60 crore and still counting.

Marigold: Year's most high profile flop, made as little as Rs 1.20 crore.

COMING SOON

Saawariya: Plays a Muslim nawab in a cameo Sanjay Leela Bhansali's timeless recreation of Dostoevsky's *White Nights*.

God Tussi Great Ho: A long-delayed project directed by Rumi Jaffrey.

Wanted: Dead and Alive: Boney Kapoor produces a remake of *Pokkiri*.